

TOSIN ADESILE ESSAY CONTEST 3.0

ESSAY THEME: One of Your Strangest Experiences on Campus and how it shaped you.

OMO DÀADÁÁ: THE DAY 0.03 CGPA CHANGED MY PERSPECTIVE

Omo dàadáá ni Emmanuel

“Omo dàadáá ni Emmanuel,” I overheard one of the staff say in Yoruba (Emmanuel is a good boy). He went on to praise my punctuality, diligence, and consistency. At that time, I was a 200-level student at the University of Lagos, majoring in Finance. Sitting quietly on the corner of the office chair, I smiled to myself, grateful for the unsolicited compliments. Then the counsellors from the university’s counselling unit walked up to me.

“What is your CGPA?” one of them asked.

“4.47, ma,” I replied, still unsure why they wanted to know.

She sighed gently. “Ah... the sponsor is looking for students with 4.5 and above. Precisely, a First-Class Student.

Her words hit me harder than I expected. And to understand how deeply that moment cut, we need to rewind a little.

How did it all start?

After a complicated and, surprisingly, completed first semester as a fresher, I found myself holding a CGPA of 4.65. Not bad at all, considering I had spent nine long months at home, thanks to the Academic Staff Union of Universities’ indefinite strike. Strangely enough, the course I read the most for that semester rewarded me with... a C.

Determined to make the second semester better, I resumed on a high note. My scholarly momentum was strong, and because the strike and other disruptions had made my first semester miserable, I decided to enjoy campus life a little. This meant attending almost every departmental and faculty event that had “Item 7” boldly printed on the flyer.

At the same time, I avoided many lectures. Why? Because, frankly, some were not worth the effort. Imagine sitting in a hall with over 300 students while the lecturer decides that microphones are unnecessary. Let me rephrase: the class wasn’t just uncondusive; it was an endurance test.

I was so confident in my exam skills that I didn't realise the danger of not giving my all during tests and continuous assessments. Still, I read like crazy. My lecture notes were so complete that even some of the most consistent class attendees borrowed from me.

Fast forward to the end of the semester, results time. My GPA dropped to 4.29. Pain. Humility. Confusion. My CGPA slid to 4.47, which, somehow, felt even more tormenting.

Facing myself

When year two began, I had to face myself honestly. Was the problem the parties and "Item 7" events? No. I had been mindful of my academics throughout. Was it skipping classes? Partly, yes. But the real culprit was my lack of seriousness with tests and assessments.

For example, I scored 12/30 on an online test. That should have been my wake-up call. But I ignored it, believing that with enough reading, I could practically write the textbook for the next set of students. The universe proved me wrong: the course I read the most for that semester ended with a D on my transcript. Just... wow.

Looking back, I realised I needed to read smart, not just hard. I also recognised the role of God's grace and prayer, because I've seen students prepare thoroughly, only to lose marks over tiny but costly mistakes.

Armed with these lessons, I stepped into year two with a renewed mind-set. I created a structured study plan, balanced my academic and social life, and stayed intentional about my goals. Around that time, I was fortunate to join the university's work-study programme. Even better, I was posted to the Expenditure and Control Unit under the bursary office, directly connected to my Finance major. The motivation to learn was high, my punctuality and diligence stood out, and for once, I felt I was exactly where I needed to be.

On this particular day, two counsellors from the counselling unit visited our office. They were chatting with a staff member about the work-study students posted there, mainly discussing attendance and consistency. After they wrapped up and were about to leave, one of the counsellors glanced at me and asked the staff, whose name has unfortunately vanished from my memory, "Is he one of the work-study students?"

“Yes,” he replied. Then he launched into an unsolicited list of compliments about me, calling me punctual, diligent, and consistent. It was the kind of praise that makes you want to check if your *halo is showing*. The counsellors seemed impressed. They whispered to each other for a moment, and I strongly suspected they were discussing whether I might qualify for the scholarship opportunity.

One of them walked up to me and asked, “What is your CGPA?”

“4.47, ma,” I replied, still unsure why she wanted to know.

She sighed gently and said, “Ah... the sponsor is looking for students with 4.5 and above.”

And just like that, they left.

I sat back in my chair, processing the opportunity that had just slipped through my fingers. Everything I did for the rest of the day was far from my usual level of brilliance. My mind was running a full marathon of “what ifs.”

One strange but useful thing I have noticed about the human brain is its ability to find something to blame for the sake of mental stability. It is why I do not take people’s complaints too personally. If blaming me for your missing biro helps you feel better before the exam, go ahead.

That day, I dug through my second semester results like a detective at a crime scene. I asked myself, what if this C had been a B? The ‘what if’ spiral kept spinning until my brain finally settled on a culprit. It was my French elective, where my final score was 66.

That semester, the lecturer split our assessment between a written test and a group presentation that involved singing and dancing to a French song. I did the test, wrote the exam, and attended the presentation, but my pride kept me glued to my seat. I refused to join the group on stage. That single act of dignity cost me marks that could have lifted my CGPA above 4.5.

Later, I asked myself if I could go back in time, would I have danced? Honestly, no. I would have probably just prepared better for the exam. Still, the whole episode stayed with

me, not just as a funny memory but as one of the strangest turning points in my campus life. It was strange because it began with unexpected office compliments and ended with me blaming a missed dance step for a missed scholarship. Yet somewhere in between, I realised that my academic journey was being quietly reshaped.

How a Strange Mix of Events Rewrote My Academic Strategy

At the time, it felt like a comedy of errors, except I wasn't laughing. But over time, I began to see the hidden value in it. I realised that having a bad semester doesn't necessarily mean you've been unserious; sometimes, it's just one of those things that happen when preparation, circumstances, and a little bit of human error collide.

I also came to understand the grace factor of God in a very real way. There were semesters when a single score of 71; instead of possible 69 made a huge difference in my GPA. Those moments reminded me that, no matter how much effort I put in, there's always a space where God's favour fills the gap.

From this, I learned that academic success is not only about reading harder but reading smarter. It's about seeing every test and assessment as a real part of the final score, no matter how small it seems. It's about showing up, even if the class feels uncondusive, and sometimes putting aside pride to take part in things outside your comfort zone.

I also learned the value of balance, making time for social events without letting them compromise my preparation. And perhaps most importantly, I learned to accept responsibility without drowning in regret, because every semester is a fresh opportunity to do better. That perspective worked: by the end of my second year, my CGPA had moved from 4.47 to 4.65.

Since then, I've approached my studies with a more strategic plan: consistent test preparation, smarter revision, participation, and most importantly, prayer. That strange mix of events became my blueprint, not my setback. I'm still maintaining and building my CGPA, waiting for another opportunity and though I still haven't danced to a French song, I've learned to move differently, both in academics and in life.